It's a miracle that with all the writing he does, Bond also finds time to read. He is partial to detective stories—"I can't write them. I tried once, but everyone who read it knew exactly who had done the murder long before the end"—and is currently reading an old Rex Stout (popular in the 1940s and '50s, he created the armchair detective Nero Wolfe) and V. Sudarshan's *Tuticorin: Adventures in Tamil Nadu's Crime Capital* (2022).

As for his life in Mussoorie, Bond is a happy homebody. He writes a page or two every day. He doesn't walk as much as before, but his grandchildren take him for drives. He has a good appetite and no dietary restrictions. "I eat all the things we're told not to eat but I do it moderately," he quips.

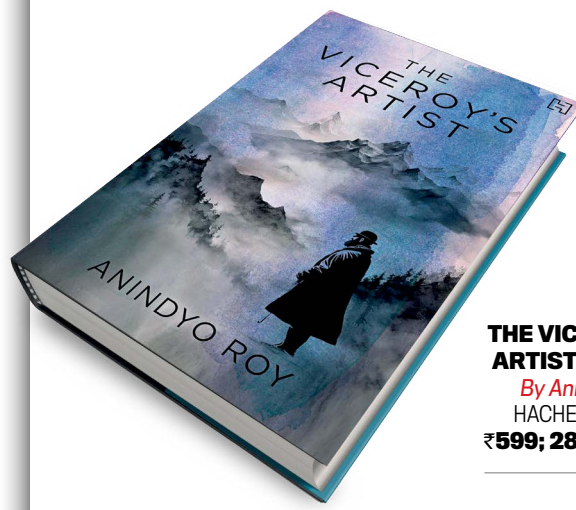
"As long as there is something to read and something to write and my adopted family around me, I am happy to sit on the mountain top," he says. I imagine him in his pyjamas, gazing fondly at Pari Tibba from his window at Ivy Cottage. He tells me he can hear the cicadas already. "Which means an early monsoon, maybe," he observes. ■

–Amit Dixit

BOOKS

PORTRAIT OF AN ARTIST & POET

ANINDYO ROY'S *THE VICEROY'S ARTIST* IS A FICTIONALISED ACCOUNT OF EDWARD LEAR'S TRAVELS IN INDIA



THE VICEROY'S ARTIST: A Novel
By Anindyo Roy
HACHETTE INDIA
₹599; 284 pages

Much childhood–and adult–delight can be attributed to a certain Edward Lear who conjured up, among other beings, an old man with a beard that housed "Two Owls and a Hen, Four Larks and a Wren", often with accompanying illustrations by the poet himself. As if mirroring his imagination, Lear travelled widely, including to India. It is this latter, less-known story that Anindyo Roy has brought to life in *The Viceroy's Artist*.

Invited by Lord Northbrook, the then Viceroy, to paint the Kanchenjunga, Lear came to India in 1873, with Giorgi Kokalis, who was employed to take care of him and with whom he shared a deep bond. As Lear criss-crossed the subcontinent, he maintained a journal, which inspired this book. It was, however, "little more than fragmentary observations" and Roy has filled in the "gaps and silence" remarkably. The text, particularly the dialogues, flow with an ease and wit that feel characteristic of Lear.

Aging and unwell when he came to India, Lear was exhausted by

The book is peppered with Lear's ideas about art, including his doubts about his own ability

the difficult journeys and sometimes officious bureaucracy. Although a guest of the highest echelons of the colonial hierarchy, he nonetheless questioned the enterprise. As Lear trundled across the country, he met a host of people, both British and Indian. He rued the fact that he was unable to learn "Hindustani", but his openness and curiosity allowed an Indian aura to infuse his verses.

The narrative is interspersed with Lear's reminiscences, which paint a vivid picture of his life. It was fraught with insecurities stemming from an unhappy childhood, unfulfilled romantic relationships, delicate health and, often, finances. Roy's rich, visual prose and occasional verse strike a balance between levity and the melancholy that marks Lear's thoughts and observations. It allows him to express his research and its subsequent rumination in a nifty fashion.

The book is peppered with Lear's ideas about art, including his doubts about his own ability. Roy has painted a compelling and poignant picture of his protagonist. We feel for Lear and root for him at every step.

A minor quibble in an otherwise editorially well-produced book is the rare clunky sentence. But these do not take away from the pleasure of the tale. Saurav Roy's illustrations follow Lear's style and are a charming touch. *The Viceroy's Artist* is an engaging and compelling story about a singular man and his times. ■

–Vineeta Rai